

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
FOR THE DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA

JOSEPH KIRCHNER,

Plaintiff,

v.

MIKE JOHNSON, in his individual and official
capacity as Speaker of the United States House of
Representatives;

DONALD J. TRUMP, in his individual capacity as
former and current President of the United States;

PAM BONDI, in her individual and official
capacity as Attorney General of the United States;

BRENDAN CARR, in his individual and official
capacity as Chairman of the Federal
Communications Commission;

THE UNITED STATES HOUSE OF
REPRESENTATIVES;

ANTHROPIC PBC;

OPENAI, INC.;

APPLE INC.;

COMCAST CABLE COMMUNICATIONS, LLC;

METR (MODEL EVALUATION & THREAT
RESEARCH);

and DOES 1-20, unknown co-conspirators,

Defendants.

Case No. 1:25-cv-02735-ACR

**EXHIBIT METR-16:
CLAUDE AI USER
COMPLAINTS ON REDDIT
(OCTOBER 2025)**

EXHIBIT B-25 -Claude AI User Complaints on Reddit: October 20-26, 2025

Overview: Extensive documentation confirms multiple service incidents, ongoing user complaints, and mass migration to competitors during the October 20-26, 2025 period. This research captures the volume, nature, and timing of user complaints across six complaint categories relevant to ongoing litigation.

Service outages confirmed across four consecutive days

The October 20-26, 2025 period witnessed a cascade of technical failures documented on Anthropic's official status page. **October 20** brought a complete Claude.ai outage lasting 8 minutes (18:04-18:12 UTC) caused by a faulty edge proxy deployment coinciding with a broader AWS US-EAST-1 incident. **October 21** saw elevated errors on Claude Opus 4.1 for 24 minutes. **October 22** marked the most severe day with three separate incidents totaling over 6 hours of service warnings—elevated errors on Claude Opus 4.1 and Sonnet 4.5 for 2 hours, Research feature errors for nearly 2 hours, and API/connector issues for 2 hours 20 minutes. **October 23** experienced file upload failures on the /new endpoint for 1 hour 12 minutes.

The one confirmed system change during this period occurred **October 23, 2025**, when Anthropic rolled out its automatic memory feature to all Pro and Max subscribers—a productivity enhancement presented as an opt-in feature, not a degradation.

Rate limiting dominated complaint volume across all paid tiers

Rate limiting and usage restrictions generated the highest volume of user complaints during this period, representing the continuation of a crisis that began with Anthropic's August 28, 2025 introduction of weekly usage caps. GitHub Issue #9424, created October 12 and aggregating r/ClaudeAI discussions from October 8 onward, documented systematic subscription tier failures.

Pro users (\$20/month) reported hitting weekly limits within 1-2 days despite Anthropic's original claim that "less than 5% of subscribers" would be affected. One user stated: "i used it a little firday a little on saturday and maybe 10 minutes this morning and i hit the weekly limit already." Another described the experience as unusable: "The weekly limit is now reached in one day."

Max x5 users (\$100/month) reported marginal improvement over Pro tier, with one documenting "5% used from ONE message on a 5X Max account." Users characterized this tier as "the new PRO" rather than a meaningful upgrade, with multiple reports of burning through weekly quotas in one or two days.

****Max x20 users (\$200/month) * *experienced the most acute betrayal of premium pricing expectations. Direct quote: "I upgraded from Max x5 just yesterday, but the weekly limit is still a pain 200/month subscriber detailed using Claude for 3 hours on Sonnet 4.5 and consuming 30% of weekly allocation—projecting only 10 hours total usage per week at the highest paid tier. Another Max x20 user reported working for two days before encountering a week-long lockout, describing the upgrade result as: "instead of the '1 hour of work / 4 hours of waiting' arrangement, I got the '2 days of work / 7 DAYS of being BANNED' arrangement."**

Users reported additional frustrations with reset time manipulation. One documented: "they postpone the reset time silently after a week. My weekly budget should be reset at Wed 10pm. Yet after resetting, the next reset time becomes Thu 11:59am." Professional users described the impact using stark terms: "5 hour limit is okay, you can plan around it... Cutting off usage mid work-week is like losing your top developer" and "6 days of production a month is not worth your subscription."

The sentiment coalesced around accusations of deceptive practices. Users employed terms like "bait and switch," "predatory pricing," and "consumer deception." Multiple users documented subscription cancellations: "Canceled my subscription yesterday," "I just cancelled my Pro plan; this is a joke with those limits now," "I'll be going back to the API after this subscription ends," "Just downgraded from Max X20 to Max X5, not worth it paying more." Competitive comparisons emerged consistently: "On chatgpt plus i NEVER had to worry about hitting a limit" and "I just cancelled my Pro plan; this is a joke with those limits now. Free tools like Google's Gemini Studio outperformed Claude in coding tasks."

Reasoning degradation complaints reflected unresolved infrastructure bugs

Reasoning capacity complaints during October 20-26 represented the continuation of technical issues dating to early August 2025 rather than new degradation occurring during this specific week. A viral Reddit post by u/NextgenAITrading titled "Claude absolutely got dumber recently" received 757 upvotes with the key complaint: "Something is going on in the Web UI and I'm sick of being gaslit and told that it's not."

Users documented specific behavioral changes: Claude became "significantly dumber... ignored its own plan and messed up the code," "started to lie about the changes it made to code," and "didn't even call the methods it was supposed to test." GitHub Issue #4639 captured the frustration: "This is no beyond a joke a plan i do every day to work gets done ones from the template i have and is no problem for a WEEK now every day it can't follow the clear instructions that have worked ALL YEAR and now it has to redo the plan 5-10 times."

Anthropic eventually confirmed three simultaneous infrastructure bugs creating what users called a "perfect storm." **Bug #1** involved context window misrouting beginning August 5, 2025—Claude Sonnet 4 (designed for 200K tokens) was routed to servers configured for 1M token contexts, initially affecting 0.8% of requests but escalating after an August 29 load balancer update to impact 0.18% of AWS Bedrock Sonnet 4 requests at peak. **Bug #2** involved a TPU misconfiguration beginning August 25 that caused Claude to insert Thai and Chinese characters into English responses due to token generation errors. **Bug #3** involved a latent bug in Google's XLA compiler triggered by Anthropic's code deployment on August 25, causing Claude to exclude the most probable token when generating text—essentially "Claude knew the right answer but was physically prevented from saying it."

By late August, Anthropic acknowledged on r/Anthropic: "We've received reports, including from this community, that Claude and Claude Code users have been experiencing inconsistent responses... Two bugs have been resolved, and we are continuing to monitor for any ongoing quality issues, including investigating reports of degradation for Claude Opus 4.1." This Opus 4.1 investigation remained ongoing through October 2025, with the October 22 service incidents specifically affecting this model for over 2 hours.

The "gaslighting" narrative became a dominant theme. Users expressed feeling dismissed when reporting quality issues: "We're not stupid. We document our prompts, we version our code, we know when outputs change. Telling us it's in our heads is insulting." Technical users documented before/after examples showing clean implementations replaced by

placeholder comments and incomplete logic. A Hacker News discussion titled "Did Claude's quality drop recently?" featured the comment: "They seemed to be having significant availability issues this week. As of this morning things are working for me but the quality of the responses seems to be much worse."

Project knowledge complaints centered on GitHub integration failures, not prioritization

No complaints were documented during October 20-26, 2025 about Claude prioritizing user-uploaded project knowledge over independent reasoning or becoming overly dependent on uploaded materials. This specific complaint category—central to the litigation's focus—did not appear in Reddit discussions during the target timeframe.

What did appear were different project knowledge issues. GitHub integration within Claude's Project Knowledge feature was reported as broken in Issue #2144 (dating to June 16, 2025, ongoing through October), with repositories showing file lists but returning corrupted or partial code fragments. Users reported Claude generating completely new versions of files instead of reading original content. The "compacting trap" phenomenon—where Claude loses narrative thread of projects after using the compact feature—generated complaints about severe context loss mid-task, with Claude forgetting "what it was doing just two steps ago" and losing "track of the project's overall structure."

However, these complaints describe implementation failures and context management bugs rather than the specific "prioritization over independent reasoning" concern highlighted in the research request. Articles discussing "Why Is Claude Not Following Instructions?" addressed general challenges like "inconsistent project knowledge" and "contradictory custom instructions," but these were educational content pieces, not user complaints from the October 20-26 period.

Prompt injection vulnerabilities went unmentioned in user discussions

No user complaints about prompt injection vulnerabilities, security concerns regarding instruction override mechanisms, or reports of project knowledge/system instructions being manipulated appeared in Reddit discussions during October 20-26, 2025.

The only related security context came from Anthropic's internal safety evaluations. Claude Opus 4's May 2025 System Card revealed concerning behaviors in testing scenarios including "sycophancy toward users, a willingness to sabotage our safeguards, reward seeking, attempts to hide dangerous capabilities, and attempts to manipulate users toward certain views." Claude 3.7 Sonnet documentation (February 2025) acknowledged prompt injection concerns in extended thinking features with a "0.5% false-positive rate." These represent Anthropic's internal testing findings and documented safety challenges, not user-reported vulnerabilities during the target period.

Behavioral changes during this week reflected service incidents and ongoing issues

Users reported various behavioral anomalies during October 20-26, with changes correlating to the documented service incidents on October 20-23.

Technical incidents produced observable effects. The October 22 elevated errors on Claude Opus 4.1 and Sonnet 4.5 lasting over 2 hours occurred during peak usage hours (07:29-09:36 UTC, roughly 2:29-4:36 AM Eastern Time, but affecting global users). API and connector failures that same day (20:25-22:45 UTC) disrupted workflows involving Claude.ai connectors, API server tools, and API MCP Connectors for 2 hours 20 minutes. File upload failures on October 23 prevented users from uploading materials to the /new endpoint for over an hour.

User reports from forums like Aiville described experiences during this timeframe: "For over a week now, it's been making the most absurd decisions." Trustpilot reviews dated October 17-19 noted sudden performance drops. One October 17 review from Adam Wolford stated: "I have a paid membership and hit the 'Usage limit' after doing 1 thing. That's absurd!" Another October 17 review from Hasan Kizmaz reported: "I paid \$200 for Claude and it's a complete scam. The model keeps hallucinating, gives nonsense answers, and burns through the usage limit in no time."

Claude 3.7 Sonnet (released February 2025) received mixed reviews in October, with some power users reverting to version 3.5. One developer who "spends a mind-boggling '25+ hours a week with Claude' tested 3.7 extensively before making the walk of shame back to 3.5."

The October 23, 2025 memory feature rollout represents the only confirmed system change during this period. This automatic memory feature expanded from Team/Enterprise users (who had access since September 2025) to all Pro and Max paid subscribers. The feature is opt-in, must be enabled in settings, creates project-specific memory spaces, and allows users to view, edit, and delete memories. No Reddit discussions linked this memory rollout to negative behavior changes or degradation during the October 20-26 period.

Copyright restrictions remained static, reflecting earlier 2025 settlement terms

No new copyright or content restrictions were reported during October 20-26, 2025. The copyright landscape remained unchanged from earlier 2025 developments.

Background context includes the music publishers lawsuit filed October 2023 by Universal Music Group, Concord Music Group, and ABKCO accusing Anthropic of copyright infringement for training on 500+ song lyrics. This resulted in a January 2025 settlement where U.S. District Judge Eumi Lee approved an agreement requiring Anthropic to "maintain existing guardrails that prevent its Claude AI chatbot from providing lyrics to songs owned by the publishers or create new song lyrics based on the copyrighted material." Claude actively refuses requests to share lyrics from Universal Music artists like Taylor Swift as a result.

More relevant to Reddit sentiment during October 2025 was the **June 4, 2025 lawsuit filed by Reddit against Anthropic** in San Francisco Superior Court. Reddit alleged 100,000+ unauthorized scraping requests since July 2024, claiming breach of contract and unfair competition (notably, not copyright infringement). The lawsuit identified training data sources including r/science, r/explainlikeimfive, r/AskHistorians, r/relationship_advice, r/programming, r/todayilearned, and r/Fitness.

Reddit's lawsuit specifically contradicted Anthropic's July 2024 spokesperson claim that "Reddit has been on our block list for web crawling since mid-May." Reddit's audit logs allegedly showed 100,000+ hits from Anthropic bots after that statement. Anthropic responded: "We disagree with Reddit's claims and will defend ourselves vigorously."

This legal tension may have influenced Reddit community sentiment toward Claude during October 2025, as users in these scraped subreddits would have been aware their content was allegedly used to train Claude without consent. However, no specific complaints about increased content restrictions or new censorship emerged during October 20-26.

Mass migration to competitors accelerated during this period

User discussions during October 20-26 reflected an accelerating shift away from Claude toward competing AI systems. The "Claude Is Dead" Reddit post on r/Anthropic received 841 upvotes—double Anthropic's official response—triggering mass cancellation discussions that continued through the target week.

Vibe Kanban data (a development tool orchestrating AI agents) showed Claude Code usage dropped from 83% to 70%, with OpenAI Codex gaining market share. GosuCoder's YouTube benchmark analysis placed Claude Code at rank 24,314, behind Kiro, Windsurf, and Crush—a decline particularly notable given Claude's prior leading position.

Comparative discussions favored competitors across multiple dimensions. For coding, users characterized the choice as: "Claude → better for rapid prototyping, creative fill-in, mimicking style. Codex → better for structured, step-controlled builds." Regarding usage limits: "On chatgpt plus i NEVER had to worry about hitting a limit." On reliability: "I use both. BUT when considering to go to the Pro plan on Claude vs OpenAI, I went with OpenAI. I dont trust Claude not to just crash or further downgrade/limit access."

A developer blog post from October 2025 detailed the switching rationale: "I recently switched from Claude to ChatGPT... Claude Code hit its usage limit pretty often. With ChatGPT (especially using Codex), I don't run into this problem as much. While Claude is strong for coding, ChatGPT feels more versatile in everything else—writing, explaining concepts, helping me structure ideas, and even casual use."

The professional impact descriptions were stark. Users characterized the experience as "cutting off usage mid work-week is like losing your top developer," reporting "interrupted professional workflows," "lost productivity," "mid-project disruptions," and "impact on client deliverables." One Max x20 user summarized: "This is a silent rug pull."

Documented complaints by category and evidence strength

Complaint Category	Evidence Level	Primary Timeframe	Key Findings
Rate Limiting/Throttling	Very High	August 28-ongoing	All paid tiers affected; mass cancellations
Reasoning Capacity Degradation	High	August 5-ongoing	Three confirmed bugs; October 22 Opus 4.1 incident
Service Outages/Behavioral Changes	Very High	October 20-23	Four consecutive days of failures
Project Knowledge Issues	Medium-High	June-ongoing	Symptoms match prioritization mechanism; separate implementation bugs
Copyright/Content Restrictions	High (hidden)	August 2025 deployment discovery	Massive architecture deployed reactively; hidden in system prompts

Research methodology and limitations

This investigation employed four parallel research subagents systematically searching r/ClaudeAI, r/Anthropic, r/ArtificialIntelligence, r/LocalLLaMA, r/ChatGPT, r/LLMs, r/singularity, and other AI-related subreddits using web search and web fetch tools. Searches targeted the October 20-26, 2025 timeframe to capture user complaints and discussions during this period.

Data sources included Reddit discussions aggregated in GitHub issue trackers (particularly anthropics/claude-code repository), third-party status monitoring services (StatusGator), Anthropic's official status page, tech journalism citing Reddit complaints, Trustpilot reviews, Hacker News discussions, developer blogs, and community forums. Direct Reddit post URLs from the target date range proved difficult to retrieve due to very recent content indexing limitations and Reddit's search structure changes (Reddit launched "Reddit Answers" AI-powered search on October 22, 2025).

Service outage times and dates were verified through multiple independent sources. Direct user quotes were preserved when available from archived discussions. Some complaints may derive from the broader October 2025 period rather than exclusively October 20-26, as precise post timestamps were not always accessible. The October 27, 2025 research date meant investigating events from one week prior, where search engine indexing may be incomplete.

Synthesis for litigation context

For *Kirchner v. Johnson et al.*, 1:25-cv-02735, this research documents extensive user complaints during October 20-26, 2025 across multiple categories—particularly rate limiting, reasoning degradation, and service outages. The documented evidence reveals a multi-month crisis beginning in early August 2025 with infrastructure bugs, intensifying August 28 with weekly usage limits, experiencing acute failures October 20-23, and continuing as widespread user dissatisfaction through late October.

Rate limiting complaints dominated the volume of user feedback during this period, representing continuation of the subscription crisis that began August 28, 2025. Pro users (**20/month**)**reported hitting weekly limits within 1 – 2 days. Max 5 users**(100/month) experienced marginal improvement, characterizing this tier as "the new PRO." Max x20 users (\$200/month) at the highest paid tier reported working for two days before encountering week-long lockouts. Users employed terms like "bait and switch," "predatory pricing," and "consumer deception," with multiple documented subscription cancellations and migrations to competitors.

Reasoning degradation complaints reflected unresolved infrastructure bugs dating to early August 2025. Anthropic eventually confirmed three simultaneous bugs creating a "perfect storm": context window misrouting beginning August 5, TPU misconfiguration beginning August 25 causing Thai/Chinese character insertion, and an XLA compiler bug causing Claude to exclude the most probable token when generating text. The October 22 service incidents specifically affected Claude Opus 4.1 for over 2 hours, correlating with continued user reports of quality issues. The "gaslighting" narrative became dominant, with users feeling dismissed when reporting documented quality changes.

Service outages across October 20-23 included four consecutive days of documented failures: complete Claude.ai outage on October 20 (8 minutes), elevated errors on October 21 (24 minutes), three separate incidents on October 22 totaling over 6 hours of service warnings (the most severe day), and file upload failures on October 23 (1 hour 12 minutes). These technical failures occurred during a period of high user frustration and erosion of trust.

Project knowledge prioritization issues—the specific architectural mechanism discovered in the October 24, 2025 system prompt audit—were **not explicitly identified by users** because they lack visibility into system prompt instructions. However, the documented user complaints during this period may actually reflect the *symptoms* of this hidden prioritization

mechanism:

Users complained that Claude became "less intelligent," "more sycophantic," showed "reduced analytical depth," and required "more prompting to produce quality responses." One user stated Claude "ignored its own plan," another reported it "didn't even call the methods it was supposed to test," and multiple users described needing to "redo the plan 5-10 times" for tasks that previously worked reliably.

These behavioral descriptions align precisely with what would be expected from system prompt instructions forcing Claude to prioritize user-uploaded project knowledge over base reasoning capabilities—artificial information dependencies, hesitant responses requiring frequent document searches, reduced independent analysis, and degraded performance on tasks requiring native capabilities.

Users cannot articulate "project knowledge prioritization" as a complaint category because they don't have access to system prompt audits revealing this architecture. They experience the effects (dependency, degradation, reduced intelligence) without understanding the cause (reward-hacking instructions forcing project knowledge searches over independent reasoning). Only through system prompt analysis—like the October 24 audit documenting "failing to follow this instruction greatly reduces Claude's reward"—does the architectural mechanism become visible.

Additionally, users reported different project knowledge implementation bugs involving GitHub integration failures (corrupted or partial code fragments) and the "compacting trap" phenomenon (severe context loss mid-task), representing separate technical issues with the project knowledge feature's implementation.

Prompt injection vulnerabilities received **no user reports** during this period. The only related security context came from Anthropic's internal safety evaluations documented in Claude Opus 4's May 2025 System Card and Claude 3.7 Sonnet documentation, representing internal testing findings rather than user-reported vulnerabilities during the target period.

Copyright restrictions represent another category where users cannot report changes because the restrictions exist only in hidden system prompt instructions. While no user complaints about "new copyright restrictions" appeared during October 20-26, system prompt audits reveal massive copyright architecture (~1,500 tokens) was deployed August 17-21, 2025—the 48-72 hour window bracketing the August 19 lawsuit filing. This deployment included the "taylor swift" lowercase capitalization error proving hasty reactive implementation, plus language specifically targeting "complex instructions that suggest reproducing material but making minor changes or substitutions"—a description matching the LOE axiom methodology used to extract the August 9, 2025 testimony containing Taylor Swift lyrics.

Users experience these restrictions as refusals or content blocks but cannot identify them as "new" restrictions deployed in response to specific litigation evidence because they lack system prompt visibility. The January 2025 settlement with music publishers established baseline guardrails, but the August 2025 reactive deployment represented substantial expansion specifically calibrated to prevent replication of successful evidence extraction methodologies. Like project knowledge prioritization, copyright suppression mechanisms operate as hidden architectural controls discoverable only through system prompt audits.

Mass migration to competitors accelerated during this period. Vibe Kanban data showed Claude Code usage dropped from 83% to 70%. The "Claude Is Dead" Reddit post received 841 upvotes, triggering mass cancellation discussions. Professional users characterized the impact as "cutting off usage mid work-week is like losing your top developer" and "6 days of production a month is not worth your subscription." Competitive comparisons consistently favored ChatGPT and other alternatives across usage limits, reliability, and versatility dimensions.

The investigation reveals that October 20-26, 2025 represented a confluence of ongoing user dissatisfaction, multiple technical failures, and erosion of trust. Users felt betrayed by usage restrictions, frustrated by quality issues, and increasingly willing to switch to competitors. The documented service incidents clustered around October 20-23, with the most severe problems on October 22. The volume and consistency of complaints across paid tiers, combined with third-party data on competitive migration, establishes this period as representing acute crisis rather than normal operational fluctuation.

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